external balancing may be the only resort available to New Delhi, at least in the short- to medium-term scenario. Modi's embrace of the United States suggests that New Delhi is guided by this structural logic. Finding an effective grand strategy inevitably requires a balancing act. Non-alignment has been India's answer to this challenge and an influential tenet of its foreign and security policy since emerging from colonial rule. This approach has in the past enabled India to avoid many of the limitations and entanglements of formal alliances, but it has also left the country in a position of shaping policy in a reactive manner.

India is now at a crossroads. China's rise and assertiveness as a regional and global power and the simultaneous rise of middle powers in the region mean that this balancing act is increasing in both complexity and importance simultaneously. China's growth presents great opportunities for positive engagement, but territorial disputes and a forward policy in the region raise concerns for New Delhi, particularly in the Indian Ocean and with Pakistan. The region itself is riddled with rivalries; a desire to balance China may push states together, while other issues divide them. The same complexity applies on the global level as well, as is evident from a degree of unpredictability in Sino–US relations.

Many in India continue to recommend handling the changing global system by pursuing friendship with, but keeping a safe distance from, major powers while building naval cooperation with regional states. For the Modi government, however, India stands to benefit from being more assertive. Already, cooperation with regional players is boosting its economy and defence capabilities and, as a pillar of the US pivot to Asia, India is finding support for an increased role as a regional power-broker. These growing partnerships do not need to bar engagement with China. Moreover, assertiveness in regional and global relations may